Strengthening the Backbone of Tribal Development

Reaching India's Last Mile Through Janjatiya Garima Utsav 2026



"Strengthen the weak. Scale the strong. Standardise what works. Support what is difficult."

Far from the corridors of power, in forested landscapes, hilly terrains and remote villages, Integrated Tribal Development Agencies quietly serve as the backbone of tribal welfare delivery. On 3 June 2026, their future took centre stage at Vigyan Bhawan, New Delhi, where the Ministry of Tribal Affairs convened the National Conclave on Strengthening Integrated Tribal Development Agencies and Projects (ITDAs and ITDPs). Bringing together Project Officers, Directors, senior administrators, policymakers and State Government representatives from across the country, the gathering sought to build a stronger, more responsive framework for tribal development in the years ahead.

Setting the tone for the deliberations, Secretary, Ministry of Tribal Affairs, Smt. Ranjana Chopra, traced the evolution of ITDAs from administrative units under the Tribal Sub Plan framework to integrated delivery platforms for tribal welfare. While these institutions collectively cover the largest concentration of Scheduled Tribe populations in the country, she acknowledged challenges such as vacancies in key positions, uneven fund utilisation, limited convergence with Central sector schemes and inadequate use of technology in monitoring and grievance redress. The conclave, she emphasised, was not merely a review exercise but a forward looking effort to create an actionable roadmap for reform.

The Minister of State for Tribal Affairs underscored the critical role of ITDAs in improving the lives of crores of tribal citizens living in Scheduled Areas and adjoining regions. He noted that flagship initiatives such as the **Dharti Aaba Janjatiya Gram Utkarsh Abhiyan (DAJGUA) and PM JANMAN** have channelled thousands of crores of rupees into tribal regions, making institutional strengthening essential for effective last mile delivery. Calling Project Officers agents of transformation, he urged them to carry the spirit of the conclave back to their districts.



The Union Minister for Tribal Affairs expanded on this vision, describing tribal communities as equal partners in India's journey towards Viksit Bharat. He called for a structural transformation in the staffing, funding and accountability mechanisms of ITDAs and announced that the Ministry is exploring a dedicated capacity building framework that would equip officers with modern governance skills, digital tools and exposure to best practices from high performing agencies.

A defining moment of the day came when the Hon'ble President of India, Smt. Droupadi Murmu, virtually inaugurated three landmark initiatives under Janjatiya Garima Utsav 2026: the Training Fab at CeNSE, IISc Bengaluru, 75 Space Labs in Eklavya Model Residential Schools (EMRSs) across the country, and the documentary film **Sabse Door Sabse Pehle.** In her address, the President reaffirmed the nation's commitment to ensuring that no tribal citizen is left behind in the journey towards Viksit Bharat.

Among these initiatives, the Space Labs programme emerged as a symbol of aspiration and opportunity. Established in 75 EMRSs across 18 states with support from Bharat Petroleum Corporation Limited (BPCL), which has committed approximately Rs 12 crore under its Corporate Social Responsibility programme, the initiative is expected to directly benefit around 50,000 tribal students. Developed under the guidance of ISRO recognised Space Tutor agencies, the labs will encourage experiential learning and scientific inquiry while opening pathways to careers in aerospace, astronomy, satellite technology and artificial intelligence. The President also expressed hope that more such laboratories would be established in the future.

The conclave featured the presentation of a Draft Short, Mid and Long Term Roadmap for Strengthening ITDAs and ITDPs by Dr. Varnali Deka, IAS. Developed through extensive consultations, State level workshops and field visits across Andhra Pradesh, Telangana, Rajasthan, Maharashtra and Gujarat, the roadmap addresses institutional capacity, human resources, fund flow, convergence and monitoring systems. Dr. Deka also highlighted the Ministry's commitment to deploying technology through the M.A.N.A.V. framework, ensuring that Artificial Intelligence remains ethical, accountable, inclusive and aligned with human aspirations.

Four thematic breakout groups deliberated on Institutional Framework and Human Resources, Fund Flow and Financial Architecture, Monitoring, Evaluation and IT Systems, and Convergence and Scheme Delivery. Their recommendations were consolidated and presented in a plenary session.

Delivering the valedictory address, Shri Manish Thakur, IAS, Additional Secretary, Ministry of Tribal Affairs, unveiled an Evidence Weighted ITDA Diagnostic Scoring Framework designed to convert the conclave's recommendations into measurable action. The framework assesses 214 ITDAs across 17 States and Union Territories using 15 parameters spread across five institutional pillars: Authority, Staff, Planning, Rights and Outcomes. Complementing this was a five level ITDA Maturity Model, ranging from a basic administrative office at Level 1 to a rights linked, data driven institution at Level 5. He emphasised that ITDAs must evolve into area development integrators capable of coordinating education, health, livelihoods, infrastructure, rights and digital monitoring. His concluding message resonated across the hall: "Strengthen the weak. Scale the strong. Standardise what works. Support what is difficult."

The conclave also recognised excellence through Awards for Top Performing ITDAs and ITDPs, honouring agencies and Project Officers who demonstrated exemplary performance in service delivery, convergence, fund utilisation and community outreach. Chief Guest Dr. Ashok Kumar Lahiri, Hon'ble Vice Chairman, NITI Aayog, commended the Ministry's systematic and evidence based approach to strengthening tribal governance institutions.

Today, ITDAs and ITDPs operate across Scheduled Areas in states including Andhra Pradesh, Telangana, Odisha, Gujarat, Maharashtra, Rajasthan, Jharkhand, Madhya Pradesh and Chhattisgarh, among others. As they channel resources under DAJGUA, PM JANMAN and allied Central schemes, the roadmap emerging from this conclave seeks to ensure that these institutions become stronger, more accountable and better equipped to serve a significant proportion of India's Scheduled Tribe population in the decades ahead.